

Ellis Island and Immigration

Connect the people, places, and changes of Ellis Island, where about 12 million immigrants entered the United States between 1892 and 1954.

? Historical challenge

Between 1892 and 1954, about 12 million people arrived at Ellis Island in New York Harbor, hoping to start new lives in America. Who came, where did they land and settle, and what changed because of them? Map how people, place, and change connect.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

History of Ellis Island from 1892 to 1954 – National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How the immigration station worked and changed over 62 years.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- When did Ellis Island open and close?
- About how many people passed through it?

SOURCES 2

Ellis Island – Immigration and Relocation in U.S. History (Library of Congress)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The inspection process arrivals went through, with primary sources.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What happened to someone arriving at Ellis Island?
- How might the wait have felt?

SOURCES 3

Ellis Island Passenger Manifests – National Archives (Prologue)

PRIMARY SOURCE

Ship passenger lists recording names, ages, jobs, and home countries.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What information did the manifests record?
- How do these records help families today?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

Ellis Island and Immigration

1892–1954

New York Harbor

Who?

Immigrant families and individuals
— arriving mostly from Europe, plus
elsewhere, hoping for work and a
new start

Immigration inspectors — federal
officers who asked questions and
decided who could enter

Doctors and nurses — who
examined arrivals for illness

Interpreters — who translated many
languages so people and officials
could understand each other

Where?

New York Harbor — the ships' entry
point to America

Ellis Island — the small island
holding the immigration station

The great hall (Registry Room) —
where arrivals were inspected

The Statue of Liberty — nearby, the
first landmark many immigrants
saw

American cities — New York,
Chicago, Boston, and beyond, where
newcomers settled

What changed?

The U.S. population grew quickly.

Cities grew larger (urbanization) as
many immigrants settled in them.

The workforce grew, supplying
labor for factories and industry.

Food, music, language, and
traditions blended into American
culture.

The nation became more diverse,
made up of people from many
lands.

How were people, place, and change connected?

Millions of hopeful people came through Ellis Island in New York Harbor, and by settling in America's growing cities and workplaces they helped make the nation bigger, busier, and more diverse.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your three lenses with a partner. Did you connect the same people to the same places and changes?
- Which change do you think mattered most to a newly arrived family? Why?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

Ellis Island (1892–1954), in New York Harbor near the Statue of Liberty, processed about 12 million immigrants, most between 1892 and 1924. Arrivals were inspected for health and questioned in the Registry Room; most passed and entered the country. Immigration fueled population growth, urbanization, a larger workforce, and a more diverse culture. The 1924 Quota Act sharply reduced immigration.

Common misconceptions

- Most arrivals passed inspection and were admitted; only a small share were held or turned away.
- Ellis Island processed immigrants; it was not a prison (though later it was used for detention).
- Immigrants came from many places, not one single country.

Vocabulary

immigration, inspection, manifest, urbanization, quota, interpreter, harbor.

Historical context

Opened Jan. 1, 1892; closed 1954; ~12 million processed; peak early 1900s; 1897 fire, fireproof Main Building opened Dec. 1900; immigration dropped after the 1924 Quota Act.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

In your own words, explain how people, place, and change connect at Ellis Island. Use at least one detail from each lens and one source.